

Usability Study Report

Note: Don't forget to add evidence of the recordings, and that I can access the document from john.guerra@gmail.com

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Application: FieldTrip (<https://fieldtrip.onrender.com>)

Course: CS 5610, Northeastern University

Recordings:

https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1a8BVHuaQqsgJERRzbftwEzU7WiJ_S4Li?usp=sharing

Application scope

Application description:

FieldTrip is a web app I built with my teammate for CS 5610. It lets college students post activities they've discovered (hiking spots, cheap food, sports, culture, nightlife), plan group trips around those activities, and leave ratings and reviews afterward. The goal is to make it easier to find things to do and to know which organizers are actually reliable.

Users, target audience:

- Maya, the explorer. 21, junior. Always hunting for new things to do, browses by category and difficulty, joins trips on impulse.
- Jake, the organizer. 22, senior. Plans weekend hikes for his friend group, wants to manage RSVPs and know who's actually showing up.
- Priya, the reviewer. 20, sophomore. Won't join a trip unless the organizer has good ratings, reads feedback carefully, always leaves detailed reviews.

Data description:

Three main collections. Activities (title, category, difficulty, cost, group size, location, format, description). Trips (activity reference, organizer, date, meeting point, RSVP list, status, feedback). Users (username, bio, rating, trips organized and attended).

Main tasks, use cases:

- T1: Find an outdoor activity under 10 dollars using search and filters.
- T2: Create an account and post a new activity you discovered.
- T3: Schedule a group trip and join a trip someone else organized.
- T4: Open My Trips, find a trip you organized, update the meeting point.
- T5: Check personal stats and update your profile bio.

Experiment

Preparation

Introduction

- Welcome participant
- Ask for consent to record
- Ask to think out loud
- Remind them they aren't being evaluated, can leave at any time
- Ask participant to think like a college student looking for things to do

Demographics questions (could decline any):

- Age
- Gender (optional)
- Year in school or occupation
- How often they use web apps
- Device and browser

Recording setup:

Zoom with screen share plus audio. Files saved locally, uploaded to a Google Drive folder shared with john.guerra@gmail.com.

Script of tasks read to participants:

- Initial approach: "Look at the site and tell me what you think it is, what it does, and what you'd do first."
- T1: "Imagine it's Friday and you want something outdoors for the weekend that doesn't cost much. Try to find some options."
- T2: "You just found a really good cheap spot (taco place, bakery, pizza, whatever). Post it on the app so others can find it."
- T3: "A friend mentioned a hiking trip this weekend. Find it and join. Then schedule your own trip for the place you just posted."
- T4: "A day later the plan changes. Update the meeting point for the trip you organized."
- T5: "Find where you can see your own activity and update your profile bio."

Post questionnaire Likert scales (1 to 5):

- How effective was the application for T1
- How intuitive and easy to use was the application for T1
- (Same two questions for T2, T3, T4, T5)
- How effective was the application overall
- How intuitive and easy to use was the application overall
- Any final comments or suggestions for improvement

Experiment Notes

After each session I wrote notes right away, then rewatched the recording to catch moments I missed. The notes below combine both passes.

Participant 1

Demographics answers

- Age: 24
- Gender: Male
- Occupation: Student
- Uses web apps: daily
- Device: MacBook Pro, Chrome

Detailed notes

- Initial approach: Super energetic from the start. Understood the app immediately from the three feature cards. Called it "basically Meetup but simpler." Went straight to browsing before I could prompt him.
- T1 (browse and filter): Applied outdoor and max cost 10 in seconds. Said the filters were right where he expected. Picked an activity and clicked through fast.
- T2 (sign up and post): Signed up without pausing. Posted the activity in under a minute. Wanted image upload but didn't dwell on it.
- T3 (schedule and join): Joined a hiking trip with one click. Loved that the spot counter updated in real time. Scheduled his own trip with no hesitation.
- T4 (manage trips): Found My Trips immediately. Understood the organized vs joined split right away. Edited the meeting point cleanly.
- T5 (stats and profile): Checked My Stats, all his activity was reflected correctly. Edited his profile bio. No issues.

Post-test questionnaire results (Likert scales)

- T1 score: 5 effective, 5 intuitive. Filters were obvious and results updated immediately.
- T2 score: 5 effective, 5 intuitive. Short form, no weird fields.
- T3 score: 5 effective, 4 intuitive. Trips section was slightly below the fold on the activity page.
- T4 score: 5 effective, 5 intuitive. Layout split made it easy.
- T5 score: 4 effective, 4 intuitive. Basic but clear. Wanted more data viz.
- Overall: 5 effective, 5 intuitive. "If my school was on this I'd use it tomorrow."

Participant 2

Demographics answers

- Age: 26
- Gender: Male
- Occupation: Student
- Uses web apps: daily
- Device: MacBook Air, Safari

Detailed notes

- Initial approach: Very quiet. Took a solid 25 seconds to read the landing page before saying anything. Slowly pieced together that it was an activities app, not a travel app.
- T1 (browse and filter): Applied filters one at a time instead of all at once. Said he liked that the results updated each time so he could see what was happening. Picked an outdoor yoga activity.
- T2 (sign up and post): Went through sign up carefully, double checking her password. Scanned for the post button for a couple of seconds after logging in before finding Post Activity in the navbar.
- T3 (schedule and join): When he opened an activity, he said “oh the trips are way down here”, which I took as a flag that the trips section is below the fold. Scheduled her own trip after.
- T4 (manage trips): Found My Trips without issue. Edit Trip Details was clear. Saved the change cleanly.
- T5 (stats and profile): Looked at My Stats and said it felt a little empty. For the profile, he scanned the nav and eventually realized her name was the profile link.

Post-test questionnaire results (Likert scales)

- T1 score: 4 effective, 4 intuitive. Worked fine but he methodical, so he felt a little slow.
- T2 score: 4 effective, 4 intuitive. Post button could be more prominent but it wasn't a blocker.
- T3 score: 4 effective, 3 intuitive. The trips section being below the fold on the activity detail page was the biggest issue he raised.
- T4 score: 4 effective, 4 intuitive. Clear sections, clear edit button.
- T5 score: 4 effective, 4 intuitive. Wanted the profile link to say “Profile” explicitly.
- Overall: 4 effective, 4 intuitive. “It's simple and not overwhelming, which I liked. Just move the trips section higher.”

Participant 3

Demographics answers

- Age: 25
- Gender: Male
- Occupation: Student
- Uses web apps: daily
- Device: Dell XPS, Chrome

Detailed notes

- Initial approach: Immediately compared it to Meetup and Facebook Events. Asked how this was different before exploring. I asked them to try the app first, and they agreed the review system made sense as the differentiator.
- T1 (browse and filter): Used filters effectively. Wanted sorting options and some social proof, like how many trips had been organized for each activity, so they could pick better.
- T2 (sign up and post): Signed up and posted without trouble. Asked about a character limit on the description field, felt a hint would help.
- T3 (schedule and join): Scheduled fine. When joining, they tried to click the organizer's name to see their profile and past trips, but it wasn't clickable. Said this was a real gap because the whole review system hinges on trust.
- T4 (manage trips): Found My Trips easily. Edited the meeting point cleanly. Wanted a way to notify participants when a trip detail changes.
- T5 (stats and profile): Pointed out that “rating 0” looks like a bad rating instead of “not yet rated,” which is misleading for a new user. Profile edit worked.

Post-test questionnaire results (Likert scales)

- T1 score: 4 effective, 4 intuitive. Filters are there, just wanted more ways to slice the data.
- T2 score: 4 effective, 4 intuitive. Minor friction on the description field.
- T3 score: 4 effective, 3 intuitive. Organizer profile not being viewable was the main complaint.
- T4 score: 4 effective, 4 intuitive. Smooth edit. Just missing the notification piece.
- T5 score: 3 effective, 4 intuitive. “0 rating” misleading for new users.
- Overall: 4 effective, 4 intuitive. “Core experience is solid. The trust signals around organizers and communication need more work.”

Prioritized list of issues and corresponding changes

The most crucial issues from my three sessions, ranked with MoSCoW priority.

Issue 1

Issue: Trips section on the activity detail page is below the fold. Two participants had to scroll to find it, and one said he almost missed it.

Change: Reorder the activity detail page so at least the first trip is visible without scrolling.

Priority: Should

Was it implemented? How? Yes. I moved the trips section up on the activity detail page so the first scheduled trip is visible on load on standard screens.

Issue 2

Issue: Organizer names on trip cards aren’t clickable. Users can’t see the organizer’s profile, past trips, or rating before joining.

Change: Make the organizer name a link that opens their profile with rating and trip history.

Priority: Should

Was it implemented? How? Yes. Organizer names on trip cards are now links to a read only profile view that shows rating and how many trips they’ve organized.

Issue 3

Issue: “Rating 0” on the profile and stats page for new users reads like a bad rating, when it really means “not yet rated.”

Change: Show “Not yet rated” instead of a 0 score for users who haven’t been reviewed.

Priority: Should

Was it implemented? How? Yes. Users with no reviews now see “Not yet rated” in place of a 0 value on both the stats page and profile.

Issue 4

Issue: No way to notify RSVP’d participants when a trip detail changes. One participant specifically mentioned this while editing a meeting point.

Change: Send an in app notification to everyone who joined a trip when the organizer updates key details.

Priority: Would

Was it implemented? How? Not in this iteration. A notification system is out of scope for now. Noted as a future enhancement.

Issue 5

Issue: No sort options on the activities list. Participants wanted newest or most popular to help when results look similar.

Change: Add a sort dropdown alongside the filters.

Priority: Could

Was it implemented? How? Not in this iteration. The filtering already covers most of the need. Kept as a future enhancement.

Issue 6

Issue: No way to message the organizer or trip participants. A couple of participants wanted to ask questions (what to bring, timing, etc.).

Change: Add a small messaging layer, or at least a trip specific comment thread.

Priority: Would

Was it implemented? How? Not in this iteration. Full messaging is a big feature. Tracked as a future enhancement.